Using OneDrive Files On-Demand to save space

Article KB0010044 | Owner: Service Desk L1 | Subcategory: Low disk space | Applies to: Windows 11 23H2/24H2 (Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840), OneDrive sync client (built-in with Microsoft 365), File Explorer

Summary

OneDrive Files On-Demand lets you view all your OneDrive files in File Explorer while storing only placeholders locally, freeing up disk space on Acme Global laptops. This article shows users how to enable the feature, move existing files to the cloud, and verify that space has been reclaimed. Service-desk agents can follow a complementary procedure to diagnose low-disk-space tickets, apply the fix, and confirm resolution.

Symptoms

- Low disk space warning pop-up from Windows
- "Disk full" error when trying to save or copy files
- File Explorer shows red drive-space bar with <?5?GB free
- OneDrive sync status icon shows a warning or paused state

Common causes

- Large numbers of locally cached OneDrive files consuming the SSD
- Temporary files, old Windows update caches, or user-saved media filling the C: drive
- Files On-Demand disabled, causing all OneDrive content to be downloaded

Preliminary checks

Before enabling Files On-Demand, confirm that the low-space condition is caused by OneDrive content. Open Settings ? System ? Storage and note the usage breakdown. If the "OneDrive" folder occupies a large share (>?10?GB) of the C: drive, proceed with the self-help steps. Also verify that you are signed into OneDrive with your Acme Global account (look for the blue cloud icon in the system tray).

Self-help procedure: Enable OneDrive Files On-Demand and move files

Follow these steps to turn on Files On-Demand, shift existing data to the cloud, and regain disk space. The process does not delete any files; it only changes how they are stored locally.

1. Right-click the OneDrive cloud icon in the system tray and select "Settings".
2. In the Microsoft OneDrive dialog, go to the "Settings" tab.
3. Under "Files On-Demand", check the box "Save space and download files as you use them". Click "OK".
4. OneDrive will begin to convert existing files to online-only placeholders. This may take several minutes depending on the number and size of files.
5. To accelerate space recovery, open the local OneDrive folder (usually C:\Users\<your-name>\OneDrive).
6. Select large folders or files you know you do not need offline (e.g., video archives, old project backups).
7. Right-click the selection, choose "Free up space". The files become online-only; a white cloud icon appears next to each.
8. Repeat until the Storage sense view shows sufficient free space (aim for >?15?GB on the C: drive).
9. Optional: Run Storage Sense manually (Settings ? System ? Storage ? Configure Storage Sense or run it now) to clean temporary files and further increase free space.

Service-desk procedure: Diagnose and remediate low-disk-space tickets

Agents should use this workflow when a user reports a disk-full symptom that is potentially related to OneDrive. The steps combine verification, user guidance, and cleanup actions that can be performed remotely via Teams or Intune.

1. Ask the user to open Settings ? System ? Storage and share a screenshot of the storage usage breakdown.
2. If OneDrive consumes >?10?GB of the C: drive, proceed; otherwise investigate other sources (temp files, Windows Update cache, personal downloads).
3. Guide the user through the self-help procedure above (enable Files On-Demand, mark large folders as online-only).
4. If the user cannot locate the OneDrive settings icon, verify that the OneDrive sync client is running (process OneDrive.exe) and that the user is signed in with their @acme.example account.

5. After the user reports completion, request a follow-up storage screenshot to confirm at least 10-15?GB of free space has been reclaimed.
6. If space remains insufficient, run Storage Sense remotely via Intune (Device actions ? Run script) or advise the user to delete large personal files (videos, ISO images) and empty the Recycle Bin.
7. Document the amount of space freed in the ticket and close with resolution "Low disk space - OneDrive Files On-Demand enabled".

Verification and closure

After the fix, confirm that the user can still access their OneDrive files without issue and that the system no longer shows low-space warnings. Provide a brief verification checklist for both users and agents.

1. Open File Explorer and browse the OneDrive folder; files should show a blue cloud icon (online-only) unless recently opened.
2. Attempt to open a file that was previously marked online-only; it should download automatically and open within a few seconds.
3. Check the OneDrive activity center for any sync errors; resolve any conflicts before closing the ticket.
4. Ensure Windows does not display a low-space toast notification for at least 24?hours.
5. Close the ticket in the service-desk system, adding the resolution notes and any relevant KB reference (KB0010044).

Prevention tips

Encourage users to keep Files On-Demand enabled by default and to periodically review large files stored in OneDrive. This reduces the chance of future disk-full incidents.

1. Set OneDrive to start with Windows and keep Files On-Demand always turned on (the setting persists across sessions).
2. Quarterly, run Storage Sense or use the OneDrive "Manage storage" view to identify large files and move them to archive storage or delete them if no longer needed.
3. Remind users to avoid saving large personal media (movies, ISO files) directly to the OneDrive sync folder; instead use external drives or SharePoint for such content.

When to escalate

If after completing the service-desk procedure the user's C: drive still shows less than 5?GB free space, or if OneDrive exhibits persistent sync errors that cannot be resolved via standard troubleshooting, escalate to the Desktop Support L2 team. Include in the escalation: storage screenshots, OneDrive sync logs (%localappdata%\Microsoft\OneDrive\logs), and a summary of steps already taken (Storage Sense runs, Files On-Demand status, files moved to online-only).

Keywords: OneDrive, Files On-Demand, low disk space, disk full, storage sense, free up space, online-only files, cloud placeholder, C: drive cleanup, Acme Global IT help